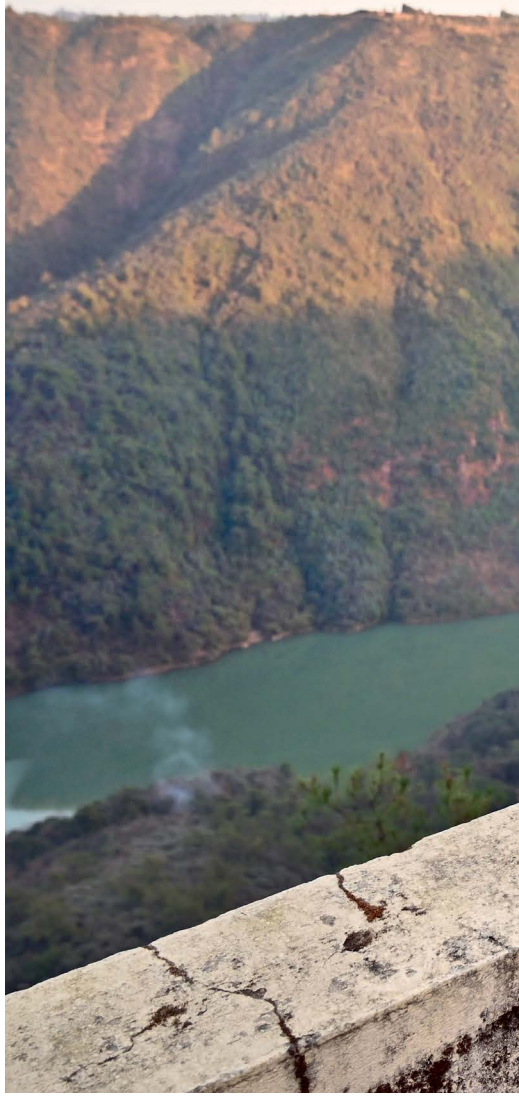
DEMOCRATISING LEARNING

Online education has made learning accessible and inclusive. Government initiatives now offer free courses to millions who need them the most

By NANDITA BORA *and* APARMITA DAS



NILOTPAL BARUAH

THE DRUDGERY

India's school education system ranks among the largest globally, encompassing nearly 1.5 million schools, over 9.8 million teachers, and approximately 248 million students spanning pre-primary to higher secondary levels. But foundational learning has been a challenge. The 2023 Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) highlights a stark reality: one-fourth of students aged 14-18 struggle to read a Class II-level text in their regional languages. The disparity between affluent and poorer students exacerbates the issue—with their parents thwarted by forbidding private education costs, underprivileged students are marooned in underfunded schools. Online education offers a transformative solution to these structural challenges by democratising access to quality learning resources.

THE EASE OF LIVING

Digital learning platforms now provide students with high-quality content from anywhere, effectively breaking the constraints of geography and inadequate infrastructure. Massive Open Online Courses (MOOCs) exemplify this shift, offering self-paced courses that cater to diverse learning needs.

Government initiatives such as SWAYAM (Study Webs of Active-learning for Young Aspiring Minds) and NPTEL (National Programme for Technology Enhanced Learning) have further democratised education, offering free or affordable courses. During the Covid-19

The **asynchronous nature of online education** allows learners to study at their own convenience

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"It helped me understand my capabilities"

Laweibabha Khongmawloh, a student from Pynter village in Meghalaya, is the third of six children born to poor parents—a daily wage earner father and a housewife mother. Laweibabha's life took an unexpected turn when the pandemic forced schools to close in 2020. When her teachers announced the shift to online classes, Laweibabha was both excited and apprehensive. The digital world was unfamiliar—she had never